

Community-Led and Youth-Led Initiatives

January – December 2024

1,634,776

individuals benefited from community-led initiatives (CLIs)

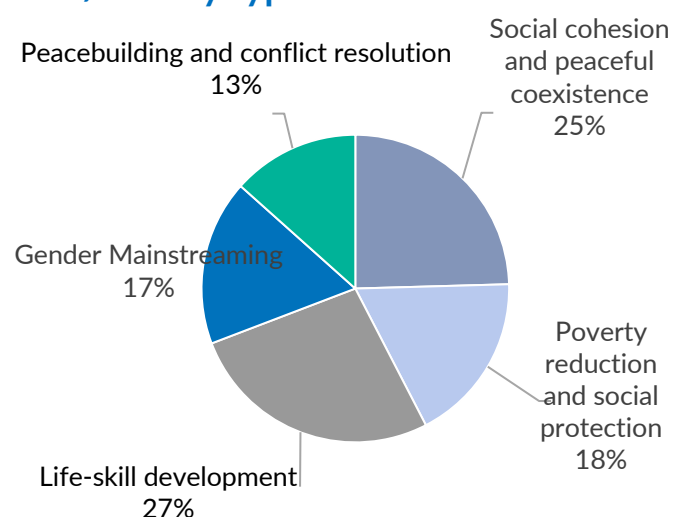
4,290

self-managed group members led the CLIs and youth-led initiatives (YLIs)

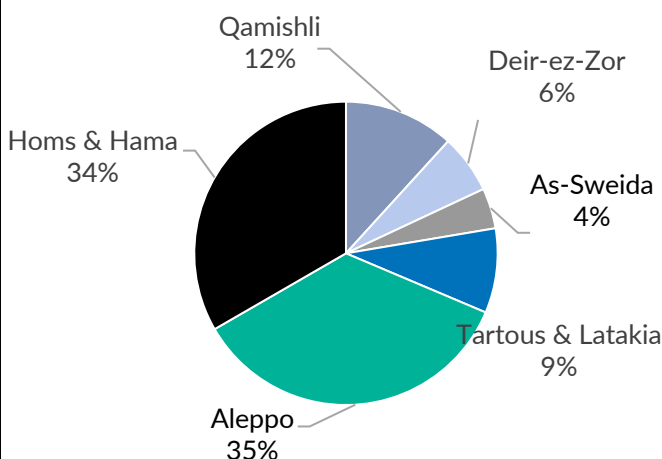
18

local partners coordinated the implementation of the CLIs and YLIs

CLIs/YLIs by type



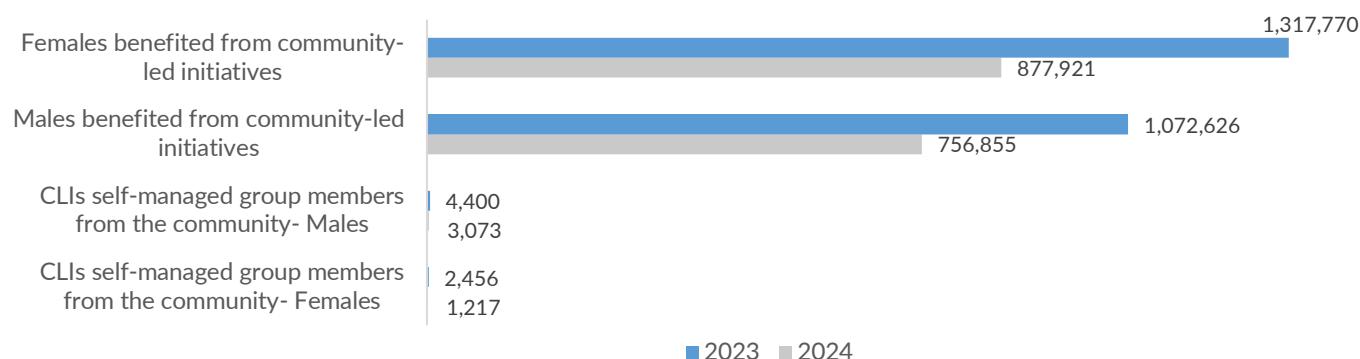
CLIs/YLIs by area



12 Governorates



18 Partners



Introduction

UNHCR supports community-led initiatives (CLIs) and youth-led initiatives (YLI) in Syria to enhance community mobilization for diverse population groups and communities. These initiatives encourage community members to come together, discuss their needs in areas such as protection, self-reliance, education, health, and individuals with specific needs, set their priorities, and subsequently design and implement projects that address these priorities. These initiatives enhance community participation, solidarity and self-management and are designed, implemented and owned by communities. Specific attention is paid to youth groups, who receive tailored training on understanding and prioritizing community needs and leading initiatives before they enter the proposal design phases. This approach ensures that the initiatives are not only responsive to the community's needs but also cultivate a sense of ownership and engagement among the participants.

UNHCR, in collaboration with its partners, mobilizes and assists communities in designing and spearheading their own initiatives, and supports these self-managed community groups by supplying the necessary materials and tools for their implementation.

Implementation

Between January and December 2024, a total of **514** CLIs and YLI were successfully implemented across twelve governorates in Syria, including Damascus and its surrounding areas, Deir-ez-Zor, Qamishli, Aleppo, As-Sweida, Dar'a, Quneitra, Homs, Hama, Idleb, Latakia, and Tartous. These initiatives were designed and led by **4,290** self-managed group¹ members from the community, consisting of **3,073** males and **1,217** females. These initiatives positively impacted over 1.6 million (including some 757,000 females) individuals through different communities. The implementation of the CLIs and YLI was carried out in collaboration with **18** local partners².

The initiatives focused on social cohesion and peaceful coexistence, life-skills development, peacebuilding, conflict resolution, poverty alleviation, social protection, social inclusion and diversity, as well as the integration of gender considerations.

The initiatives are categorized under the following themes:

- **Community-Engagement and Mobilization:** Efforts taken by the leading community groups to foster increased involvement among community members. A good example of this is the focus group discussion meeting that was convened with members of the Deir-Hafer village community in Aleppo governorate, who exhibited readiness to engage, possessed considerable financial resources, and had robust connections within the community. The purpose of this meeting was to introduce the "Eid Smile" initiative and to facilitate the donation process for collecting fabrics, toys, and clothing. Subsequently, discussions were held with women engaged in tailoring to enlist their assistance in mending and producing clothing for the children identified by the initiative. All efforts were directed towards sorting and packaging the donated items, which were then organized at the community centre for the beneficiaries of the initiative, in collaboration with the child protection and psychosocial support teams in the centres.

¹ A group from within the community that designs, implements, and manages a community-led initiative.

² Partners included: Syrian Society for Social Development (SSSD), Syrian Arab Red Crescent (SARC), Childcare, Monastery of St. James the Mutilated (MSJM), Namaa, Al-Ihsan, Taalouf, ALNADA, Tamayouz, PUI, Al Batool, GOPA, AKF, Aoun, SCS, Syria Trust and Baraem.

- **Awareness-Raising and Training:** CLIs falling under this category are mainly designed and implemented by community members who have the needed skills and knowledge to carry out training and awareness-raising on specific areas proposed, based on assessed needs. For instance, in Raas-Albasit region (Latakia Governorate), a group of displaced women has taken the lead in producing mosquito screens, which are then distributed to populations who are most at-risk, such as children and the elderly, to protect them from mosquito that can result in widespread Leishmaniasis infections. The increased number of Leishmaniasis cases has emerged due to the presence of landfills and swamp areas. Furthermore, the initiative included educational sessions led by the local dispensary team³ and the self-managed group, emphasizing infection control and the vital role of hygiene in disease prevention.
- **Production and Distribution Campaigns:** An initiative which encompasses the construction and repair of 200 desks for a school in Ashara village, Deir-ez-Zor, was implemented. The Education Directorate's limited resources have hindered the provision of new school desks. Consequently, the deteriorating conditions of the desks also led to physical injuries, including bruises, cuts, and even fractures due to accidents involving broken furniture. Local volunteers, including parents and teachers, helped in organizing and coordinating the project, ensuring that the efforts are aligned with the specific needs of the school. The involvement of the community fostered a deeper sense of ownership and accountability by creating safe spaces for the children to thrive academically. These projects also strengthened bonds between communities in order to improve overall conditions for school children.
- **Self-Reliance:** One of the initiatives implemented in 2024 focused on promoting domestic agriculture among female students and their families in Rural Damascus. It promoted that empowerment of women by engaging them in agricultural production for self-sufficiency while revitalizing the rich agricultural heritage in Darya city. Women and girls received training utilizing the fertile soil and favourable climate to cultivate crops that fulfil their nutritional needs, with surplus crops sold to generate a monthly income, thereby addressing unemployment and the rising cost of living. Community members, including farmers and agricultural experts, served as mentors, offering guidance and hands-on assistance to the women and girls involved in the project. This collective effort strengthened the agricultural capacity of the region while promoting social cohesion, as communities worked together to cultivate their land and ensure food security. The initiative not only empowered women but also encouraged intergenerational learning, with older community members passing down valuable skills and traditions and fostering long-term sustainability and self-sufficiency.
- **Small-Scale Rehabilitation:** In 2024, an initiative aimed at guaranteeing access to clean drinking water through the restoration of the control and sterilization facility linked to the Al-Zeer well in the Al-Bayada area in Homs, was implemented. This enabled the General Water Corporation to efficiently repair and restore the well, thereby safeguarding the residents of northern Al-Bayada from health hazards associated with relying on water sourced from tank deliveries or unregulated wells, which often posed risks due to inconsistent water quality, thus alleviating some of their daily challenges and stress. Local volunteers helped manage the collection, treatment, storage, and distribution of drinking water, ensuring that it reaches every household in need. Furthermore, the residents took part in educating the community about the importance of using clean water and maintaining hygiene practices, helping to reduce the spread of waterborne diseases.

³ This involves both professional staff at the local health dispensary as well as trained community members with a background in health who are actively supporting service delivery in this domain.

- **Social Cohesion and Peaceful Coexistence:** These types of initiatives primarily focus on building strong relationships within communities, promoting inclusivity, understanding, and cooperation among diverse groups. The goal is to create a harmonious environment where individuals feel a sense of belonging and mutual respect. The rehabilitation project for the Albukamal Youth Stadium (Deir-ez-Zor Governorate) aimed at enhancing the environment for children eager to participate in sports, particularly football. Local volunteers—including youth, parents, and sports leaders—contributed to supporting the stadium’s renovation. Their efforts, which included repainting walls, clearing debris, repairing goalposts, and tidying the seating area, were carefully aligned with the community’s needs. Additionally, the community actively participated in organizing sports events and tournaments, ensuring the facility is used to its full potential and remains a vibrant hub for interaction, skill-building, and social integration.

Example of Community-Led Initiatives

“Hand in Hand”, Banyas, Rawda.

The initiative was designed to equip a room, in Banyas (Tartous Governorate) generously donated by a community member with vital medical supplies such as walkers, wheelchairs, blood pressure monitors, etc. These items will be available for loan to community members in need. The initiative targets internally displaced persons and returnees, particularly elderly men and women, as well as vulnerable individuals with medical emergencies. A group of individuals from the community with medical training will also support by providing basic first aid until patients can be transported to the nearest medical facility. This project aims to address healthcare challenges arising from the limited availability of local medical services and expenses associated with traveling to the nearest healthcare providers.



The equipped room in Tartous, ©UNHCR Tartous Field Office